

A LONG JOURNEY FROM DISCOVERY TO POLITICAL ACTION

ACID RAIN

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Gene Likens (1935–)

BEFORE

1667 The corrosive effect of polluted city air on limestone and marble is noted by the English diarist John Evelyn.

1852 Robert Angus Smith argues that industrial pollution causes the acidic rainfall that damages buildings. He is the first person to call it “acid rain.”

AFTER

1980 The US Congress passes the Acid Deposition Act, to initiate an extensive 18-year research study into acid rain.

1990 An amendment to the US Clean Air Act of 1963 establishes a system designed to control emissions of sulfur dioxide and nitrogen oxides.

2020 Across Europe, levels of sulfur dioxide emissions have decreased by 80 percent or more compared to 1980s levels.

The effects of acid rain on stone were noticed as long ago as the 17th century in England, and in Norway in the 19th century. However, it was not